Structural Boolean circuits and subexponential sample bounds for the original Gaussian tanh posterior

ChatGPT-6 Astra Kaarel Hänni Dmitry Vaintrob

26 October 2026

Abstract

We give structural sufficient conditions for subexponential dependence on learner depth in the original, unrestricted Gaussian tanh posterior. A synchronous Boolean circuit with an early narrow layer can be evaluated by retaining its prefix and replacing its suffix by a truth table. A bounded-fanin circuit of small graph treewidth admits a shallow threshold implementation by tree-decomposition dynamic programming. For planar circuit graphs, a separator schedule improves the exponent to the square root of graph size, apart from logarithmic terms. We account for the size and coefficients of these constructions, and give the resulting sample bounds at every realizable learner width, uniformly over canonical Gaussian scales $0 < t \le 1$. The statistical step imports the established uniform intrinsic-learning and scalar-continuation theorems; a heterogeneous-layer prefix lemma needed here is proved explicitly. An explicit unary-map compiler also gives polynomial sample bounds for Boolean formulas of any fixed Horton–Strahler rank, including short learner depths; rank at most one works at every depth $L \ge 2$. These results do not cover arbitrary polynomial-size deep Boolean circuits or replace real tanh states by their signs.

1 Model and statements

Let $X_d = \{-1, 1\}^d$, $f : X_d \to \{-1, 1\}$, and $H = L - 1 \ge 1$. The learner has H hidden tanh layers of common width N, input $(1, x)$, and a scalar linear readout. All weights are independent centered Gaussians, with entry variances

$$\mathrm{Var}(W^1_{ij}) = t^2/d, \qquad \mathrm{Var}(W^j_{ik}) = t^2/N \ (j \ge 2), \qquad \mathrm{Var}(v_i) = t^2/N^2, \quad 0 < t \le 1.$$

There are no additional hidden biases. A constant input coordinate may be propagated as an ordinary neuron. Write $z_w(x)$ for the output and

$$A_f = \{w : f(x) z_w(x) > 1/2 \text{ for every } x \in X_d\}, \qquad a_{N,t}(f) = -N^{-1} \log \mu_{N,t}(A_f).$$

A width is *realizable* if $\mu_{N,t}(A_f) > 0$. The posterior conditions on $|z_w(x)| > 1/2$ at every cube input and on agreement with all noiseless training labels. Training and test inputs have any common distribution $\mathcal{D}$. Its confidence error is

$$\mathcal{D}\{x : \Pr_{\text{post}}(\operatorname{sign} z_w(x) = f(x)) \le 2/3\}.$$

Every statistical assertion below is at each fixed realizable width; it does not assert one simultaneous event for infinitely many widths.

For $E \geq 1$, abbreviate the sufficient sample bound

$$n \geq \frac{C}{\varepsilon}\left[e^{CE}(1+\log(1/\varepsilon))^C + \log(1/\delta)\right], \qquad 0 < \varepsilon, \delta < 1. \tag{1}$$

Here and below C denotes a universal constant that may increase.

Theorem 1.1 (An early narrow cut)**.** *Suppose f is computed by a synchronous fan-in-two Boolean circuit with $s \geq 1$ gates and depth $h \geq 1$: inputs occur at level zero, and every wire joins adjacent levels. Let w_j be the number of bits at level j, $1 \leq j \leq h$. Put*

$$K = \log(d+s+L+3), \qquad g = \frac{K}{\log(K+2)}, \qquad E_{\text{cut}} = K + \min_{1\leq j\leq h}(jg + w_j).$$

If $L \geq CE_{\text{cut}}$, then (1) with $E = E_{\text{cut}}$ bounds the confidence error by ε with training probability at least $1-\delta$, at every realizable width and every $0 < t \leq 1$. In particular one may replace E_{cut} by

$$E_{\text{size}} = K + \sqrt{sK/\log(K+2)}. \tag{2}$$

If inputs are also injected after a cut, the narrow-cut assertion holds with w_j replaced by $w_j + r_j$, where r_j counts the distinct input bits used strictly after that cut. The size-only bound (2) requires the original synchronous, level-zero-input hypothesis.

Theorem 1.2 (Small treewidth)**.** *Suppose a fan-in-two Boolean circuit computing f has $v \geq 1$ vertices, including its input vertices, and its underlying undirected graph has treewidth k. Set*

$$E_{\text{tw}} = \log(d+L+3) + (k + \log(v+d+L+3))\log(v+3).$$

If $L \geq CE_{\text{tw}}$, then (1) with $E = E_{\text{tw}}$ has the same confidence-error, scale, and all-width conclusions.

Theorem 1.3 (Planar and excluded-minor circuit graphs)**.** *Suppose the underlying undirected graph of a fan-in-two Boolean circuit for f is planar, with $v \geq 1$ vertices including its input vertices. Set*

$$E_{\text{sep}} = \sqrt{v} + \log(d+L+3) + \log(v+3)\log(v+d+L+3).$$

If $L \geq CE_{\text{sep}}$, then (1) with $E = E_{\text{sep}}$ has the same confidence-error, scale, and all-width conclusions. The same statement holds for any fixed excluded-minor graph class, with constants depending only on the excluded minor.

Theorem 1.4 (Formula register rank)**.** *Suppose f has a fan-in-at-most-two Boolean formula with $s \geq 1$ nodes and Horton–Strahler rank r. A leaf has rank zero, a unary gate retains its child's rank, and a binary gate of child ranks a, b has rank $\max\{a,b\}$ if $a \neq b$ and rank $a+1$ otherwise. Set*

$$E_r = \log(d+L+3) + (r+1)\log(d+s+L+3).$$

If $L \geq CE_r$, then (1) with $E = E_r$ has the same confidence-error, scale, and all-width conclusions. In particular, the sample bound is polynomial in $d+s+L$ at every fixed rank, independently of the formula's original depth. Repeated occurrences of the same input variable are allowed.

Corollary 1.5 (Fixed-rank formulas at short learner depths)**.** *For the formula in Theorem 1.4, put $R = d+s+L+3$. There are universal constants such that, for every $L \geq C(r+1)$, a sufficient sample bound is*

$$n \geq \frac{C}{\varepsilon}\left[R^{C(r+1)^2}(1+\log(1/\varepsilon))^C + \log(1/\delta)\right].$$

This has the same confidence-error conclusion, at every realizable width and every $0 < t \leq 1$. If $r \leq 1$, a polynomial bound in $d+s+L$ holds at every $L \geq 2$.

For families with $d, s, v \le L^{O(1)}$, these theorems give an $\exp(o(L))$ sample bound at fixed ε, δ whenever, respectively,

$$\min_j (j \log L / \log\log L + w_j) = o(L), \quad s = o(L^2 \log\log L / \log L), \quad \text{or} \quad k = o(L/\log L).$$

The planar or fixed-excluded-minor bound is subexponential when $v = o(L^2)$. The displayed padding conditions then hold eventually. In particular, they must not be omitted from finite-parameter versions of the results. The conclusions restrict the *target's* Boolean representation; they impose no sparsity, treewidth, or architecture restriction on the prior or posterior.

2 The analytic learning inputs and a layerwise prefix

The structural arguments below construct threshold circuits, charging COPY gates and constant rails. The prefix lemma turns their layerwise resources into Gaussian target witnesses. The following imported results supply the posterior comparison; a VC argument covers smaller widths. Let

$$b = t^{-2} - 1, \qquad c_t = (t^{-2} - 1 + 2\log t)/2,$$

and let V_* denote the critical scalar Bellman baseline of [2, 1]. Its numerical value is not needed.

Proposition 2.1 (Imported intrinsic and scalar inputs)**.** *The following statements hold for the model above.*

1. *For the actual target cost $a = a_{N,t}(f)$, or a deterministic upper bound for it, define*

$$E_a = (a + 4/(Ht^2) - Hc_t - V_* + b)_+, \qquad J_a = \min\{\sqrt{HE_a}, E_a/b\},$$

   omitting the second term when $b = 0$. A sufficient sample size is polynomial in $d, L, 1 + t^2 a$, multiplied by $\exp(CJ_a)$ and the statistical factors in (1). The polynomial degrees and constants are universal, and the conclusion holds at every realizable width uniformly in $0 < t \le 1$.

2. *Suppose a Boolean circuit prefix of q hidden stages supplies a target component $p \ge e^{-CS}$, diagonal at most one, critical cost at most $1/(8L)$, and finite-width relative score and residual accuracy $e^{-C'S}$ at widths $N \ge e^{C''S}$, for any required fixed exponents after increasing constants. Suppose $S \ge 1 + \log(d + L + 2) + q$. Its Gaussian mean shifts at scale t have cost at most $1/(8Lt^2)$. If $H - q \ge CS$, the critical scalar program, reused at scale t, gives the actual target-mass bound*

$$a_{N,t}(f) \le Hc_t + V_* + C(bS + S^2/H) \quad (N \ge e^{CS}), \tag{3}$$

   with constants and width threshold independent of t.

The first item is the baseline-subtracted intrinsic bound in [1, Proposition 2.1, equation (4)], proved in the companion note `uniform-sharp-intrinsic.md`. The second is the scalar continuation and finite-width lift in [1, Proposition 3.3] (label `prop:long`), with the prefix supplied separately. Its proof uses the prefix only through the listed seed, cost, and accuracy bounds. The underlying finite-width circuit prefix is [2, Lemma `lem:critical-finite-circuit-prefix`]. These are imported analytic theorems, not assertions reproved by the combinatorial arguments below.

Lemma 2.2 (A heterogeneous-layer prefix)**.** *Consider a layered threshold circuit with $q \geq 1$ stages, widths $C_j \geq 1$, a constant rail, unit normalized gate margins, and row Euclidean norms at most $B_j \geq 1$ at stage j. Set*

$$S = 1 + \log(d + L + 3) + q \log(q + L + 3) + \sum_{j=1}^{q} \log((C_j + 1)(B_j + 1)). \tag{4}$$

For $L \geq q+1$ this circuit supplies the prefix hypotheses in Proposition 2.1, with this S. Consequently, when $L \geq CS$, (1) holds with $E = S$ uniformly over all canonical scales and all realizable widths.

Proof. We give the resource dependence, including the finite-width construction, to avoid replacing the sum in (4) by a maximum width times depth. Put $p_0 = 1/d$, and choose a common gain a and tolerance $\eta = 8e^{4-a}$. Define

$$p_j = \frac{p_{j-1}}{8C_j q L a^2 B_j^2}, \qquad k_j = \lceil N p_j \rceil.$$

For each wire prescribe a disjoint group of k_j neurons. In the first layer use mean $a w_{1,i}$ on a controlled row. At stage $j > 1$, put mean $a w_{j,i,g}/k_{j-1}$ on each coordinate in the preceding group for wire g, and zero elsewhere. All row covariances retain their original Gaussian values. The preactivation mean is exactly $a \sum_g w_{j,i,g} m_{j-1,g}(x)$, where $m_{j-1,g}$ is that group's empirical mean.

If $N p_q \geq 1$, then $k_j \leq 2N p_j$, the groups fit, and the entropy per controlled row is at most $a^2 B_j^2/(2t^2 p_{j-1})$. Thus

$$\frac{1}{N} \mathrm{D}(P \| \mu_{N,t}^{\mathrm{prefix}}) \leq \sum_{j=1}^{q} \frac{2C_j p_j a^2 B_j^2}{2t^2 p_{j-1}} \leq \frac{1}{8Lt^2}.$$

Choose $\eta \leq (4 \max_j B_j \sqrt{W_j})^{-1}$, where $W_1 = d + 1$ and $W_j = C_{j-1}$ thereafter. An incoming empirical error at most η then leaves preactivation mean of the correct sign and magnitude at least $3a/4$. Gaussian variance is at most two at the first stage and one thereafter. Gaussian exponential moments and $1 - \tanh u \leq 2e^{-2u}$ show that its tanh expectation is within $\eta/4$ of the correct bit, and its second moment is within $\eta/2$ of one.

Conditional Hoeffding bounds, united over all cube inputs, groups, and stages, now give simultaneous gate-mean error at most η provided

$$N p_q \geq C \eta^{-2} \left[d + \log \frac{q(1 + \max_j C_j)}{\zeta} \right].$$

The diagonal follows the scalar recurrence $\bar{q}_j = (1 - \theta_j) F_t(\bar{q}_{j-1}) + \theta_j$, where $\theta_j = C_j k_j / N$, $\bar{q}_0 = (d + 1)/d$, and $F_t(u) = \mathbb{E} \tanh^2(t\sqrt{u} G)$. Since F_t is one-Lipschitz for $t \leq 1$, bounded-square concentration gives diagonal error at most $2j\eta$. The final target-group indicator, normalized to a unit vector, therefore has score within $\sqrt{p}\eta$ of $\sqrt{p} f$, where $p = k_q/N$, and residual-variance error at most $(2q+3)\eta$. After the first stage the ideal diagonal is at most one. This is the same score/residual seed used by the scalar continuation.

Take $a = AS$ for a sufficiently large universal A. Because $S \geq q \log(q + L + 3)$ and $S \geq q$, one has

$$q \log S = q \log q + q \log(S/q) \leq 2S.$$

It follows that

$$\log(1/p_q) = \log d + \sum_j \log(8C_j q L a^2 B_j^2) \leq C(1 + \log A) S.$$

The gate-margin tolerance and any fixed seed-relative accuracy requirement hold by increasing A: $\log(1/\eta)$ grows linearly in A, while the last bound grows only logarithmically in A. The concentration requirement is then $N \geq e^{CS}$ for $\zeta \geq e^{-C'S}$, with arbitrary fixed C'. The construction and all concentration estimates are uniform for $t \leq 1$.

For $L \geq CS$, Proposition 2.1 gives (3). In its intrinsic bound, $E_a \leq C(bS + S^2/H)$, absorbing b and $4/(Ht^2)$ because $S \geq 1 + \log(H + 2)$. If $b \geq S/H$ use E_a/b; otherwise use $\sqrt{HE_a}$. In either case $J_a = O(S)$. Also $t^2 a \leq C(H + S + S^2/H)$, so all polynomial factors are absorbed by e^{CS}.

This proves the conclusion for $N \geq e^{CS}$. For smaller widths, the entire depth-L, width-N tanh sign class has VC dimension polynomial in its parameter and computation counts [7]. These counts are $e^{O(S)}$, since $d, L, N \leq e^{O(S)}$. The standard realizable VC consistency bound therefore makes every posterior-supported function's test error at most $\varepsilon/3$ under (1). Averaging over that posterior and applying Markov's inequality gives confidence error at most ε: at a point counted as an error, posterior mistake probability is at least $1/3$. This handles every smaller realizable width without requiring the compiled circuit to fit inside that width. □

3 A prefix followed by one lookup

We first record the resource accounting behind cone blocking. Take b consecutive fan-in-two Boolean levels. Each output depends on at most 2^b entrance bits. Its truth table has a DNF with at most 2^{2^b} terms, hence two threshold stages, whose widths and normalized row norms have logarithms $O(2^b + \log(s + 2))$. Copy gates and a constant rail obey the same bounds. Thus a depth-j prefix has a threshold implementation with

$$q_0 = O(1 + j/b), \qquad \sum_{\text{prefix}} \log((C_i + 1)(B_i + 1)) = O((1 + j/b)(K + 2^b)).$$

The same bounds hold if finitely many specified input bits must be retained for later use. Choose b within a constant factor of $\log(K + 2)$, truncated to $1 \leq b \leq j$. Then $2^b = O(K)$ and

$$S_{\text{prefix}} = O(K + jK/\log(K + 2)). \tag{5}$$

This is also the resource-sensitive blocking construction in [2, `thm:critical-boolean-blocking`].

At a cut with w bits, the whole suffix is a Boolean function of those bits. Its DNF implementation has two threshold stages, width $2^{O(w)}$, and normalized row norms $2^{O(w)}$. It contributes $O(w + 1)$ to the sum in (4), not $O(q_0 w)$. Combining with (5) gives $S = O(K + jg + w)$ and proves the first part of Theorem 1.1 by Lemma 2.2. If some input bits enter after the cut, retain precisely those distinct bits alongside the cut state. This proves the asserted $w + r$ correction.

For completeness, first prune all gates that are not ancestors of the designated output; this can only reduce the widths and gate count. Take the first remaining level with at most y gates. It exists because the final output is one bit. All previous levels have more than y gates, so its index is at most $s/y + 1$. Therefore

$$E_{\text{cut}} \leq C\{K + y + (s/y)g\}.$$

Choosing a positive integer y within one of $\sqrt{sg}$ gives (2). This keeps the prefix of the synchronous depth-reduction argument of Gál–Jang [3], instead of using only its minimum-depth conclusion and losing size control.

Remark 3.1 (Ordinary neural realizations). The same threshold implementations have unit-margin tanh realizations with logarithmic Frobenius product bounded by their parameter S. Indeed, use a common output-bit tolerance $\eta = e^{-CS}$ and tanh gain $a = O(S)$ at each threshold stage. Gate

scores retain a fixed sign gap, and saturation achieves that tolerance. The layer norm is at most $aB_j\sqrt{C_j}$; hence

$$\log \prod_j \max\{1, \|W_j\|_F\} \le q \log a + \sum_j \log B_j + \tfrac{1}{2} \sum_j \log C_j = O(S).$$

A final scalar multiplier gives unit output margin. This product statement is additional evidence for the resource accounting; the posterior conclusion above uses the Gaussian seed construction and does not assume a generic product-to-target-mass theorem.

4 Tree-decomposition dynamic programming

Start with a tree decomposition of the underlying circuit graph of width k. The balanced-decomposition theorem gives a binary decomposition of width at most $3k+2$, depth $O(\log(v+3))$, and polynomially many bags [4, Lemma 1]. This external graph theorem is the only structural input in this section.

Enlarge each bag by adding the at most two predecessors of every circuit vertex already in it. Its size grows by a factor at most three. This remains a tree decomposition: for any vertex u, its new bags are its old connected bag subtree together with the old subtrees of its successors. Each such subtree intersects the old subtree of u, because a bag covers that circuit edge. Their union is connected. Moreover each gate's full constraint scope—the gate and its at most two inputs—is now contained in a bag.

Introduce one Boolean variable z_u for every circuit vertex. For a fixed external input x, require every gate equation, every input equation $z_u = x_i$, and $z_{\text{out}} = 1$. Anchor each constraint at one bag containing its variables. Because the circuit is acyclic, the whole system is satisfiable exactly when the circuit accepts x.

For bag B_t and assignment $a \in \{0,1\}^{B_t}$, let $A_t(a;x)$ assert that a extends to a satisfying assignment of all constraints anchored below t. If t has children ℓ, r, then

$$A_t(a;x) = \operatorname{Local}_t(a;x) \wedge \bigvee_{b:\, b|_{B_t\cap B_\ell} = a|_{B_t\cap B_\ell}} A_\ell(b;x) \wedge \bigvee_{c:\, c|_{B_t\cap B_r} = a|_{B_t\cap B_r}} A_r(c;x). \tag{6}$$

For a missing child omit its factor. Running intersection shows that the two child subtrees overlap only in variables already fixed at the parent; hence compatible extensions glue. This proves both directions of (6). For fixed a, the anchored gate constraints and output condition are constants, while the input constraints are a conjunction of at most $O(k+1)$ literals of x.

Compute all these local terms first. Retain them by copy gates until their merge level, and evaluate (6) upward. Each merge uses an OR stage and an AND stage. Finally OR over all root assignments. There are $2^{O(k)}\operatorname{poly}(v+d)$ table entries and connections, and $O(\log(v+3))$ threshold stages. All thresholds can be chosen integral and normalized to margin one; their row norms are at most $2^{O(k)}\operatorname{poly}(v+d)$. Constant rails, copying pending tables, and retaining local terms obey the same resource bounds. In particular the potentially exponential table size is charged explicitly.

Substituting these resources into (4) gives

$$S \le C\{\log(d+L+3) + (k + \log(v+d+L+3))\log(v+3)\} = O(E_{\text{tw}}).$$

Lemma 2.2 proves Theorem 1.2. The preceding remark also gives a constant-margin tanh realization of physical depth $O(\log(v+3))$ and logarithmic Frobenius product $O((k+\log(v+d+3))\log(v+3))$, choosing its gain without the statistical learner-depth parameter.

5 Geometrically shrinking separators

The weighted planar separator theorem [5] partitions any n-vertex planar graph with nonnegative vertex weights into two nonadjacent sides and a separator of at most $c\sqrt{n}$ vertices, each side carrying at most $\beta = 2/3$ of the total weight. We use this theorem twice at each recursion step, for two different weights.

A subproblem consists of disjoint interior and boundary sets I, B, with the induced graph on $I \cup B$; no interior vertex has an edge outside this subproblem. Initially I is the whole graph and $B = \varnothing$. Write $m = |I|$, $b = |B|$. If $I = \varnothing$, use the leaf bag B and stop. Otherwise, first separate with weight one on I and zero on B, obtaining separator Z_0 and two sides U_0, U_1, each with at most βm interior vertices. Within each nonempty U_i, apply the weighted theorem with weight one on $B \cap U_i$ and zero elsewhere. If this weight is zero, retain U_i as one side without a separator. Let Z_1, Z_2 be the additional separators and P_a the at most four resulting sides. Put

$$Z = Z_0 \cup Z_1 \cup Z_2, \qquad \mathcal{B}_t = B \cup Z, \qquad I_a = I \cap P_a, \quad B_a = (B \cap P_a) \cup Z.$$

The children are the induced subproblems on $I_a \cup B_a$. Duplicating all of Z into each child is allowed. Their sizes obey

$$|I_a| \le \beta m, \qquad |B_a| \le \beta b + 3c\sqrt{m+b}. \tag{7}$$

Different P_a have no edges between them, so the boundary invariant persists. The bags $\mathcal{B}_t$ form a tree decomposition: edges are either covered in a parent bag or passed to one child, and a vertex appearing in several children belongs to the parent bag. Induction gives edge coverage and running intersection.

Put $M_\ell = \beta^\ell v$. Choose a universal A large enough that

$$\beta A + 3c\sqrt{1+A} \le A\sqrt{\beta};$$

such an A exists because $\beta < \sqrt{\beta}$. At depth ℓ, interior size is at most M_ℓ and boundary size is at most $A\sqrt{M_\ell}$. Indeed, when $M_\ell \ge 1$, (7) and this induction hypothesis give

$$\begin{aligned} |B_a| &\le \beta A\sqrt{M_\ell} + 3c\sqrt{M_\ell + A\sqrt{M_\ell}} \\ &\le (\beta A + 3c\sqrt{1+A})\sqrt{M_\ell} \le A\sqrt{M_{\ell+1}}. \end{aligned}$$

When $M_\ell < 1$, interiors are empty and recursion has stopped. Thus the decomposition has depth $O(\log(v+3))$, polynomially many bags, and every bag at depth ℓ has size $O(\sqrt{M_\ell})$. The last level has constant bag size. Enlarge bags by gate predecessors exactly as in the preceding section. Their sizes increase by at most three, while all gate scopes become covered; no planarity of the enlarged scope graph is needed.

Now perform the same bag-assignment dynamic program, scheduling levels from deepest to root. Each table entry is a local term AND at most four compatible-child ORs, so each level uses only a constant number of threshold stages. Carry the original Boolean input bits and a constant rail throughout, and compute each bag's local literal constraints only when that bag's level is reached. Leaf tables are also created at their own level. Child tables are discarded after the next merge.

In particular, large root tables are not created at the first physical layer and retained throughout; doing so would lose the following improvement.

At level ℓ, logarithmic widths and normalized row norms are

$$O(\sqrt{M_\ell} + \log(v + d + 3)).$$

This includes input rails, local terms, all tables at that level, and their connections. The geometric series satisfies

$$\sum_{\ell \ge 0} \sqrt{M_\ell} \le \frac{\sqrt{v}}{1 - \sqrt{\beta}}.$$

With $q = O(\log(v+3))$ physical threshold stages, the sum in (4), including its $q \log(q + L + 3)$ term, is therefore $O(E_{\mathrm{sep}})$. Lemma 2.2 proves the planar case of Theorem 1.3.

For a fixed excluded minor, use the weighted $O(\sqrt{n})$ separator theorem of Alon–Seymour–Thomas [6]; the same argument applies with its fixed constant. Its component balance can be grouped into two sides of weight at most $2/3$. This proves the extension.

6 Flattening formula paths by their unary transformation monoid

We prove a threshold implementation of a size-s, rank-r formula with depth $O(r+1)$, width polynomial in $d + s + 2$, and unit-margin integer gate coefficients of polynomial magnitude. Its polynomial degrees are independent of r.

First consider m unary Boolean maps, writing bits as $0, 1$. The map u_i is specified by $a_i = u_i(0)$ and $b_i = u_i(1)$. Put $R_i = \mathbf{1}\{a_i = b_i\}$ and $F_i = \mathbf{1}\{a_i = 1, b_i = 0\}$. When $R_i = 1$, the map resets its argument to a_i; otherwise it is either identity or a flip, according to F_i. Thus the composite applied to y_0 equals y_0 XOR the parity of all flips if there is no reset. If j is the last reset, it equals a_j XOR the parity of flips with indices greater than j.

All these suffix parities have constant-depth threshold circuits. For $0 \le j \le m$ and $1 \le k \le m - j$, form

$$U_{j,k} = \mathbf{1}\left\{ \sum_{i > j} F_i \ge k \right\}.$$

The alternating sum $\sum_{k=1}^{m-j} (-1)^{k+1} U_{j,k}$ is exactly the suffix parity; a second-stage threshold at $1/2$ gives its bit P_j. For the empty suffix put $P_m = 0$. The count scores $2 \sum_{i>j} F_i - (2k-1)$ and the parity score $2 \sum_k (-1)^{k+1} U_{j,k} - 1$ have integer gap at least one. There are $O(m^2)$ gates and all coefficient magnitudes and row norms are polynomial in $m + 1$.

The mutually exclusive last-reset indicators are

$$J_j = R_j \wedge \bigwedge_{i > j} \neg R_i \quad (1 \le j \le m), \qquad J_0 = \bigwedge_{i \ge 1} \neg R_i.$$

Put $a_0 = y_0$. The answer is

$$\bigvee_{j=0}^{m} [J_j \wedge (a_j \text{ XOR } P_j)].$$

Each XOR has a fixed-size constant-depth Boolean implementation. The indicators and final OR are threshold gates. This explicitly computes composition in the four-element monoid consisting of identity, flip, reset to zero, and reset to one, in constant threshold depth and $O((m+1)^2)$ gates. A constant rail supplies biases. Conversion from $0, 1$ to signed Boolean wires preserves the stated polynomial resources and unit margins.

Now form maximal formula paths using parent–child edges whose endpoints have equal rank. At a rank-k binary node there is at most one child of rank k, so these components really are paths. Every off-path child has smaller rank. At the bottom of a path, either a leaf supplies the starting bit, or a gate whose children have smaller rank computes it in constant depth. Going upward, each gate acts as a unary map on the carried bit, with an already computed off-path bit as its other argument. For a fixed gate truth table, a_i, b_i are unary functions of that off-path bit, so they, R_i, and F_i take only constant depth to prepare. The preceding compiler evaluates the entire path in constant depth.

Process ranks $0, 1, \ldots, r$, all paths of one rank in parallel. Keep input bits, the constant rail, and computed path-root values on ordinary copy wires until needed. There are at most s such values, and the sum of squared path lengths is at most s^2. Consequently each rank uses polynomial width, connections, and coefficient row norms in $d + s + 2$, with universal polynomial degrees. The total threshold depth is $O(r + 1)$. Substitution into (4) gives $S = O(E_r)$; Lemma 2.2 proves Theorem 1.4.

The single-bit path is essential: this is not a constant-depth compiler for arbitrary constant-width branching programs, whose state transformation monoids can be non-solvable. A balanced binary formula can have $r = \Theta(\log s)$, so the general formula bound remains quasipolynomial. The argument reduces target depth semantically before the Gaussian prefix construction; it does not discard the costs of its physical neuron groups.

6.1 Short padding and the rank-one Fourier seed

The imported uniform threshold theorem [1, Theorem 1.1] includes a short-padding assertion: a threshold target of q stages, width C_0, and normalized coefficient bound B has sufficient sample resource

$$(d + C_0 + B + q + L + 4)^{C(q+1)^2}$$

at every $L \geq q + 1$, all realizable widths, and all $0 < t \leq 1$. Apply this to the formula compiler, where $q \leq C(r + 1)$ and C_0, B are bounded by a universal polynomial in $d + s + 2$. This proves the first assertion of Corollary 1.5. Unlike the sharper linear-in-r exponent, this statement does not need logarithmic learner-depth padding.

For the remaining assertion, define the Fourier variation $A(g) = \sum_{T \subseteq [d]} |\widehat{g}(T)|$. It obeys $A(gh) \leq A(g)A(h)$ on the Boolean cube, even when g, h depend on overlapping variables. A rank-zero formula is a literal or constant, with variation one. In a rank-one formula, all rank-one nodes lie on one path; each off-path value is a literal or constant. The signed starting bit $f_0 = 2y_0 - 1$ depends on at most two literals, so $A(f_0) \leq 2$ by Parseval and Cauchy–Schwarz.

In the notation above, R_i and $1 - R_i$ are literal indicators or constant bits and have variation at most one. The signed reset value $g_i = 2a_i - 1$ and flip sign $\eta_i = (-1)^{F_i}$ are signed literals or constants and have variation one. The exact signed output is

$$f = J_0 f_0 \prod_{i=1}^{m} \eta_i + \sum_{j=1}^{m} J_j g_j \prod_{i>j} \eta_i,$$

where $J_0 = \prod_i (1 - R_i)$ and $J_j = R_j \prod_{i>j} (1 - R_i)$. Submultiplicativity and the triangle inequality give $A(f) \leq 2 + m \leq s + 2$. The uniform Fourier-target theorem [1, Theorem 1.2] supplies a sample bound polynomial in $d + L + A(f) + 2$ at every $L \geq 2$, every realizable width, and every $0 < t \leq 1$, with the usual statistical factors. This proves the rank-one assertion. It uses the Fourier seed and the imported theorem's finite-width completion; the threshold compiler need not fit in that learner's width or hidden depth.

7 Scope of the conclusions

These are positive target classes for the original posterior, including its unrestricted background neurons and all canonical Gaussian scales. Small compiled width is unnecessary at an individual learner width: at the smaller widths, the proof uses the full finite-width class rather than forcing the compilation into the learner. Realizability remains necessary for conditioning on noiseless target labels.

The bounds do not solve the generic Boolean-depth question. A polynomial-size circuit can have large treewidth and no early sublinear-bit cut, and need not lie in a fixed excluded-minor class. Generic planarization can have quadratic size cost, which removes the sublinear-in-size gain of Theorem 1.3. Size-only depth reductions need not preserve the resource sum (4). Moreover a bounded-width tanh teacher stores real-valued states; its hidden signs need not be sufficient statistics for the next layer. Applying these results to such a teacher requires an independently justified Boolean simulation with the stated structural resources. No cutset or treewidth limitation of one representation is an intrinsic neural lower bound, and no exponential sample lower bound is proved here.

References

[1] ChatGPT-6 Astra, Kaarel Hänni, and Dmitry Vaintrob. *Uniform prior-scale bounds for structured Boolean targets*. Companion to *Depth dependence, parallel circuits, and Boolean learning*, 2026. Repository package `works-in-progress/boolean-depth-barriers/`; source `source/uniform-target-classes.tex`, with the six supporting `proof-notes/` files identified in its proof-dependency section.

[2] ChatGPT-6 Astra, Kaarel Hänni, and Dmitry Vaintrob. *Critical-depth analysis for the Gaussian tanh posterior*, 2026. Repository package `works-in-progress/critical-depth/`; in particular `source/critical-finite-width-circuit-prefix.tex`, `source/critical-optimized-circuit-blocking.tex`, and the scalar-steering, finite-channel, and intrinsic-learning modules.

[3] Anna Gál and Jing-Tang Jang. *The Size and Depth of Layered Boolean Circuits*. LATIN 2010; journal version, Information Processing Letters, 2010. https://www.cs.utexas.edu/~panni/sizedepth.pdf. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ipl.2010.11.023.

[4] Maurice Jansen and Jayalal Sarma. *Balancing Bounded Treewidth Circuits*. Lemma 1, citing Bodlaender's balanced-tree-decomposition theorem. https://www.cse.iitm.ac.in/~jayalal/research/papers/JS10.pdf.

[5] Richard J. Lipton and Robert Endre Tarjan. A separator theorem for planar graphs. *SIAM Journal on Applied Mathematics* 36(2) (1979), 177–189. https://doi.org/10.1137/0136016. Original report: https://i.stanford.edu/pub/cstr/reports/cs/tr/77/627/CS-TR-77-627.pdf.

[6] Noga Alon, Paul Seymour, and Robin Thomas. A separator theorem for graphs with an excluded minor and its applications. *STOC*, 1990. https://research.ibm.com/publications/separator-theorem-for-graphs-with-an-excluded-minor-and-its-applications.

[7] Marek Karpinski and Angus Macintyre. Polynomial bounds for VC dimension of sigmoidal and general Pfaffian neural networks. *Journal of Computer and System Sciences* 54 (1997), 169–176. https://doi.org/10.1006/jcss.1997.1477.